

The Tragedy of Being Taslima

A scapegoat of identity politics, she is still a nowhere woman

I am searching for a room...where I can do whatever I like—not think about the past or the future—sing a song at the top of my voice, make some tea and sip while I write a terrific poem.” The spotlight fell on a young woman, confident in a blue saree and cropped hair. The culture-toting *bhadralok* stared mesmerised, while politicians and media bigwigs patted each other on the back for “discovering” an exotic star on Kolkata’s literary horizon. Those were the days.

A decade later, Taslima Nasreen is still a nowhere woman. The *dhotiwallahs* are no longer with her. Hounded out of her dream city by a day of communal violence, hopping from one undisclosed location to another, she is once again playing an extraordinary game of hide-and-seek with fate. Will she ever find her “home”? Does she know anymore what a “home” means? Or is she just smiling her hallmark careless smile, “*Amar kichhu jay ashena* (I couldn’t care less)”?

It wasn’t always like that. As a poorly-paid, young medic in Dhaka, she did “care” when she journeyed around in a rickshaw, treating women and experiencing their lives. She cared enough to write: about women pelted to death at the behest of the mullahs; women who cried for giving birth to girls, terrified of being thrown out of home; who came to her from their marital beds with torn vaginas (“Why shouldn’t I write about what I’ve seen? I’m a doctor, remember! No, I will not keep quiet.”)

Sadly, she is retelling the same tales. Unlike a Salman Rushdie, exile has taken away the very basis of her relevance as a moral compass, a secular-radical voice, in a traditional South Asian and Muslim culture—questioning the countless crimes of violence on women within the home, in the world of work, “the state and the church”. Nasreen knows that. “There’s nothing on the other side of the river,” she writes, “but I’ll touch this emptiness once/ and run against the wind/ I’ll dance someday and then return.” Hence, her desperate urgency to return to Kolkata—the closest port from home. Call it the biggest loss for a writer: Nasreen has nothing new to say anymore.

No wonder, all her books in exile are autobiographical. The more she focuses on her person, the more the attention shifts from her work to her private life. It was all right for Middle Bengal so long as she was a victim of religious bigotry and sexual oppression. But the moment her personal journey mirrored a woman, in control of her body and mind, that empathy disappeared. It is hard to handle sexual candour from a woman.

In 2004, just as *Dwikhandito* was branded “communal” and banned in Bengal (rumour ran wild that it was clobbered down by those intellectual luminaries she had had a tryst with, for fear of being identified), Nasreen was barred from commemorating two deceased Rabindrasangeet masters—all because she was “improperly dressed” in jeans and a shirt. Did she say, “*Amar kichhu jay ashena*” to the apparently sympathetic and liberal *bhadralok*, too?

“She is either the bravest or the most foolish person I’ve ever met,” a friend goes on record. Nasreen has been walking the fine line between the two for far too long. All for a room of her own.

by Damayanti Datta

were taking me to the airport so that I could return to Kolkata. After a while, I understood I was being dumped to Delhi,” she told INDIA TODAY (see interview).

It is common knowledge that she is not particularly popular among the Kolkata literati. An acquaintance who doesn’t wish to be named, says, “She hardly had any friends in the city.” She is known as a woman who courts publicity. In 2003, the literary establishment was sharply divided over the third part of her autobiography, *Dwikhandito*, which was banned by the state ostensibly for fear that it would hurt religious sentiments. The real reason, however, was apparently its sexual content. Though the ban was lifted in 2005, it was probably the turning point in Kolkata’s attitude towards Nasreen. She was, meanwhile, planning permanent settlement in the city.

EXPRESSPHOTO



HYDERABAD BLUES: Nasreen being attacked at a book launch function

She was even thinking of moving out of the three-bedroom flat at 7 Rawdon Street for a better address. “All I want is to return to Kolkata and resume writing from my residence. Let the Centre take a decision so that I may live there. I don’t want to be harassed any more, pressured any more. I am a Bengali. I write in Bengali. Bangladesh has closed the doors on me. I can’t exist as a writer if I am not allowed to live in West Bengal,” she told INDIA TODAY.

She should know that certain secular parties can’t exist without appeasing the minority votes, even if it means Taslima Nasreen can’t exist as a Bengali writer.